

Daily Science Anecdote

Topic: Can't Have Nice Things!

by Ali Hamdan

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As of this writing, there is a light bulb that has been operating continuously since 1901. It has been burning for almost 125 years; it was one of the earliest hand-built light bulbs. Now, despite modern technology, our light bulbs last an average of only two years. But why?

This is why we can't have nice things. Basically, if you manufacture a product that lasts too long, you quickly realize that once a customer buys it, they won't return to buy another. So, in Geneva, Switzerland just before Christmas in 1924 there was a secret meeting of top executives from the world's leading light bulb companies. These companies formed what became known as the Phoebus Cartel (*Phoebus, an epithet of the Greek sun god Apollo*), this group was made to help each other. In 1923, OSRAM (*a light bulb company*) sold 63 million light bulbs, but the next year, they sold only 28 million. Light bulbs were lasting way too long, so these companies agreed to make short-lasting light bulbs. So all companies provided samples and all light bulbs were placed on a stand, if a light bulb lasted way longer than intended, the company would get fined. So the companies worked on making their light bulbs last a specific duration, and it worked. This Cartel died when world war II came, but companies are still limiting the lifetime of light bulbs.

This practice is not limited to light bulbs; Apple did something similar with the iPod as its battery's life span is only 18 months, and a battery repair was expensive to the point where buying a new one was better. Apple was trying to get consumers to buy more iPods instead of buying one and disappearing. This practice now applies to phones, textiles, and consumer electronics to keep you buying new ones. Newer car models make previous ones look old and outdated, and people keep on getting the newest iPhone. This was all done to get profits and control the market, but unfortunately, I don't think that we can get everlasting light bulbs anymore.

Oh look down there! A light bulb!

